

Small but fierce: can micro brands shake up the luxury watch industry?

Caroline Zirakzadeh

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Abstract:

The term 'micro brand' has become one of the most used, and most contested, labels in contemporary watch culture. This article traces the origins of the movement, profiles some of the names that defined it, examines how it differs from independent watchmaking, and asks the harder questions: where does this go? Can these brands scale without losing what made them worth following in the first place?

Keywords:

Micro brands; independent watchmaking; direct-to-consumer; crowdfunding; luxury watch industry; Swiss watchmaking; transparency

Introduction

The micro brand story does not begin with a watchmaker. It begins with the internet, and specifically with the collapse of the traditional information asymmetry that had protected Swiss retail pricing for decades. By the late 2000s, enthusiast forums, such as WatchUSeek, Timezone, The Rolex Forums and many more, had created a globally connected community of buyers who understood exactly what a movement cost to produce, what a Sellita SW200 was worth, and why a watch retailing at CHF 2,800 in a boutique might contain components available to any importer for a fraction of that price.

Into this environment stepped a generation of founders who were watch lovers first and businesspeople second. They understood the community, spoke its language, and were prepared to offer something the established industry had never considered: full transparency. Where did the movement come from? Here is the supplier's name. What

does the case cost? Here is the factory in Guangzhou. Why is this priced at USD 350? Here is the full cost breakdown.

This transparency fueled rapid demand response. Crowdfunding via Kickstarter tested ideas in real-time—a mechanical chronograph under \$1,500 for complication fans? Funded in days. Unique 38mm divers with sector dials or guilloché patterns? Batched at 200 units to match forum buzz, slashing inventory risk (Time & Tide 2022). No chase for ultra-wealthy clients; these targeted collectors put passion over prestige, using accessible boutique parts to deliver value (see the many available on Alibaba, 2026). Sell-outs bred loyalty, evangelists, and a blueprint for disrupting entry-luxury complacency (Onva 2025).

Names That Defined the Movement

While the exact number of micro brands available is impossible to assess (due to the fast entry and even faster exit from the market for micro brands), industry sources tend to gravitate towards 500 – 600 different micro brands (Sangamon Watches, 2025). Any account of the micro brand era must grapple with the diversity of what the label contains. Some brands were built around a single strong aesthetic idea; others around a price point; others still around a founder's personal obsession. The names in Annexe 1 are not a ranking, but a map of how different the terrain is. Micro brands originate from a multitude of countries, not only from Switzerland: their roots are in Singapore, France, UK, Switzerland, Japan and so many more. Their DNA is also eclectic: some play with the shape of the watch case (who said it had to be round?), others with specialty materials, others with sophisticated dials while some simply try to produce a good functioning watch at an excellent price point.

Micro Brand vs. Independent: Where the Line Is Drawn

The confusion between micro brand and independent watchmaker is understandable but there are consequential differences. The distinction is not merely one of scale. Independent watchmakers are generally defined not only by ownership independence

but also by their level of horological integration, often including proprietary movements and in some cases in-house manufacturing capabilities.

The confusion arises because the most ambitious micro brands are consciously moving toward independence. Christopher Ward's in-house caliber is the most visible example, but Baltic has spoken openly about the aspiration, and several others are investing in movement development. The trajectory, for the best of them, is from micro brand toward small independent, but it is a long road, and most will not travel it.

There is also an attitudinal difference worth noting. The independent watchmaking world is largely indifferent to market disruption; its practitioners are absorbed in the work itself. The micro brand world is energized by the disruption. Its founders talk about changing the industry, exposing the markup, democratizing quality. These are different motivations, and they produce different kinds of companies.

The Future: Four Paths Forward

The micro brand segment is now mature enough to ask harder questions. The founding generation of brands — many now approaching their tenth year — faces a strategic moment. Growth requires capital. Capital implies partners. Partners bring agendas. Four paths present themselves.

Path One: Remain a micro brand, deepen the craft

The purist route is to resist external capital, stay direct-to-consumer, and reinvest profits into product development. Baltic appears to be on this path. The risk is that without investment, the move toward in-house manufacture — the thing that would genuinely separate a brand from its competitors — remains aspirational. The watch industry's history is littered with brands that stayed small by choice and remained permanently capped at a certain level of prestige.

Path Two: Strategic Investment from a Non-Conglomerate Partner

For a micro brand in the CHF 2,000–5,000 range with a proven community and growing revenues, this is a plausible scenario. The key is finding a partner whose interests align with the brand's independence — rare, but not unprecedented. The risk is that minority investments have a way of becoming majority ones when revenues disappoint or founders want liquidity. This would be the most realistic strategy for a micro brand to dive into the world of independent watchmakers. Some of them have successfully transitioned, like Christopher Ward, which now produces its own movement for certain models (WatchPro, 2019)

Path Three: Conglomerate Acquisition

The structural problem is cultural. Micro brands exist in explicit opposition to everything a conglomerate represents: opacity, retail markup, celebrity endorsement, the mystique of inaccessibility. The moment a beloved micro brand is absorbed into a group, the community that made it valuable begins to question its authenticity. This is not hypothetical — it is precisely what happened to several independent names that accepted group ownership in the 1990s and lost their collector following as a result.

A conglomerate acquisition could work if the acquiring group was willing to maintain genuine operational independence, invest in manufacture, and resist the temptation to move the brand upmarket at a pace that outruns its credibility. These are demanding conditions. They require a discipline that large groups, under quarterly earnings pressure, rarely sustain. The large advantage for a conglomerate would be to get quick feedback on the consumers' thoughts, on the trends. Despite their many luxury Boutiques, traditional brands are still more removed from the consumer than micro brands. These are in constant communication with an ever-growing network of watch enthusiasts.

Path Four: Expansion into partnerships with retailers

Some micro brands like Norquain have decided they needed the best of both worlds: they continue to launch small ad-hoc collections for their community, but they have also expanded with 250 retail partners around the world (New York Times, 2024)

What the Industry Is Watching

The micro brand segment will not disappear. It has demonstrated that a real market exists for thoughtfully made watches at honest prices, and that community trust is a form of brand equity as durable as heritage — perhaps more so, because it must be maintained actively rather than simply inherited. Some of the other issues than the ones mentioned above that pertain to the micro brands are the After Sales Service and the reputation of the brand above a certain price level. Are consumers willing to accept the risk that there might no longer be parts (or as a matter of fact a place to send your watch for repair) a few years after the purchase? If they are, at what price level is there an inflection, where the certainty of knowing your traditional watch will be serviced outweighs the coolness and other factors of the micro brand?

It also remains to be seen whether any micro brand will make the full transition: from a single founder's vision to a sustainable institution with horological authority, without losing the transparency and directness that built its following. The watch industry has not seen this happen yet. Christopher Ward is the closest case study, and its trajectory over the next five years will be watched carefully.

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Annexe 1:

Baltic (France, est. 2017)

Founded in Paris by Étienne Malec, Baltic has become one of the most visible European microbrands thanks to its vintage inspired mechanical watches and strong online storytelling. The brand operates primarily through direct online sales and produces watches typically priced between €600 and €1,200. Baltic is frequently cited by collectors and enthusiast media as one of the most successful recent European microbrands (Fratello Watches, 2023).

Formex (Switzerland, est. 1999, repositioned 2016)

Formex is a Swiss independent brand that gained visibility after shifting to a direct to consumer model around 2016. The company is known for technically advanced cases, interchangeable components, and COSC certified mechanical movements. Formex has built a strong reputation among collectors for delivering high technical specifications at relatively accessible prices (Baldassarre, 2023).

Christopher Ward (United Kingdom, est. 2004)

Christopher Ward is widely considered one of the most commercially successful brands to emerge from the microbrand movement. The company pioneered a direct to consumer business model combining Swiss manufacturing with online distribution. Revenue grew

from roughly £10 million in 2020 to about £45 million by 2024, reflecting strong global demand for its watches (WatchPro, 2024).

Unimatic (Italy, est. 2015)

Founded in Milan by Giovanni Moro and Simone Nunziato, Unimatic produces minimalist tool watches characterized by industrial design and limited production runs. The brand frequently collaborates with fashion and design labels, helping expand its visibility beyond traditional watch collectors. Many limited editions sell out quickly, reinforcing the brand's cult following (Fratello Watches, 2023).

Zelos (Singapore, est. 2014)

Zelos is widely known among collectors for its use of unusual materials such as bronze, meteorite dials, and forged carbon. The brand produces limited batches that often sell out quickly through online releases. Zelos has developed a strong community of collectors and is often cited as one of the most successful Asian microbrands (Microbrand Watch World, 2022).

anOrdain (United Kingdom, est. 2015)

Based in Glasgow, anOrdain specializes in handmade enamel dials produced in house, a rare capability for a small watch brand. The company's artisanal approach and limited production volumes have created long waiting lists for some models. anOrdain watches typically sell between €1,000 and €2,500 and are highly regarded among collectors (Baldassarre, 2023).

CODE41 (Switzerland, est. 2016)

Founded in Lausanne by Claudio D'Amore, CODE41 positions itself as a "community driven watch brand," involving collectors directly in product development decisions. The

company sells primarily online and emphasizes transparency about manufacturing costs and supply chains. Since its launch, the brand has reportedly sold more than 60,000 watches in over 90 countries (CODE41, 2023).

Norqain (Switzerland, est. 2018)

Norqain is a rapidly growing Swiss brand founded by Ben Küffer. The company combines sport-oriented watch design with strong partnerships in skiing and outdoor sports. Norqain expanded quickly into international retail networks and reportedly exceeded CHF 20 million in annual revenue within a few years of launch (Morgan Stanley and LuxeConsult, 2023).

Laventure (Switzerland, est. 2017)

Laventure, founded by designer Clément Gaud, produces vintage inspired sport watches in extremely small production runs. The brand focuses on high quality finishing and distinctive materials such as bronze and ceramic. Limited releases often sell out quickly and have developed strong demand on the secondary market (Fratello Watches, 2023).

Louis Erard (Switzerland, est. 1931, repositioned 2019)

Louis Erard repositioned itself in recent years through collaborations with independent watchmakers and designers such as Alain Silberstein and Vianney Halter. The brand produces distinctive limited edition mechanical watches at relatively accessible price points. This collaboration strategy has significantly increased its visibility among collectors (WatchPro, 2023).